cosmopolitanism of these interactions is nicely captured by the experience of the Buddhist monk Vajrabodhi who, in the eighth century, travelled from the Tamil-speaking Coromandel coast on a Persian vessel to Java and then on to Guangzhou in southern China. The variety of tradable goods was diverse, and included Arabian horses, Indian spices, and Chinese silk. Thriving Muslim and Tamil-speaking communities emerged in Chinese port towns like Quanzhou. The exchange of goods and religion was also accompanied by other interactions. The spread of Buddhism facilitated the diffusion of painting and musical methods, medicinal and astronomical knowledge, and sugar production from India to China. At the same time, India imported such things as gunpowder and paper-making technologies from China. [36]

Gunpowder Empires: Medieval India, 637–1707

Some major political and technological developments resulted in a transition from ancient to medieval India. Notably, the Islamic invasions of India eventually resulted in political rule or dominance over large parts of north India by Muslim rulers. In 637, an Arab naval expedition reached the west coast of India. But such early forays only translated into a permanent political presence in 712, when Muhammad bin Qasim, a kinsman of the ambitious governor of Iraq, defeated Raja Dahir of Sindh. Later, Mahmud of Ghazni (in what is now Afghanistan) started raiding the Gangetic plains and Gujarat and extended Islamic rule to Punjab. Soon after that, another Afghan-based warrior now popularly known as Muhammad Ghori invaded India at the head of an army that included Turkic and Tajik slaves. The institution of military or elite slavery was a Turkic and Persianate import; rulers in Baghdad recruited Turks in this manner from Central Asia. Both Mahmud of Ghazni and Muhammad Ghori were primarily raiders rather than state-builders, who sought to bolster their armies and derive revenue through plunder. These invasions also brought travellers such as al-Biruni, born in what is today Uzbekistan, whose initial interests in astronomy and